If you're here reading this book today, it may be because you've had your own muffin moment, or maybe you see it on the horizon and you're trying to avoid it. Time and time again we have the illusion that more money will solve our spending problems, but we know from experience and from countless stories like Haley and Justin's that more money only gives more fuel to spending fires.

Your income is your greatest tool for getting the things you need and want from life, but we live in a world that is intentionally designed to compel you to spend it. From childhood hardships to well-crafted advertising, without the knowledge of how to spend money well, we will continue to spend again and again on things that don't get us what we truly want. Wherever you're at right now, whether you're trying to increase your income, optimize it, or free yourself from the need for so much of it, values-based spending can help. It's what will allow you to make better spending decisions with your money now, and it's also what will prepare you for when you do earn more in the future!

But our spending is always going to be limited to the income we have at the given moment. So now the question becomes: How do we afford the things we love without unlimited income?

What Matters Most

Our friend Allison grappled with this question. She and her husband, Matt, had over $111,000 of debt living on two teachers' salaries. She thought she was doing well with money. She knew how much money was coming in every month and would spend all the way down to zero. "My ultimate goal was to not overdraft, and I was really good at it. I thought that as long as I wasn't going into the negatives, that I was great."

Until she got pregnant.

She realized they couldn't afford childcare or for her to stay home with their baby. Much less the medical bills, diapers, and every other expense that would come up. Like most of us, Allison couldn't afford everything. Without an unlimited income, she couldn't afford daycare, debt, and all the impulse purchases at the same time. So, she prioritized. She saw that the quickest way to free up income for daycare was paying off debt, so they made that their number one priority.